

Story1

That's Barbara in the third row from the back of the sanctuary, the one with the sunglasses holding up her tangle of orange hair, see her? Hair like a nest of copper wiring? The one slowly rocking? Both hands beneath her belly as if she were holding a large salad bowl; she's more than eight months pregnant. It's February 12, 1966, and Barbara's in the new Shaarey Zedek in Southfield, six exits away from Chicago Boulevard, Detroit, where the old synagogue used to be. It's still there, actually. Now they've sold it to a Pentecostal church. It's been four years since the congregation decamped to the suburbs, and the new place still gleams. The fresh paint smells like vanilla, and the triangular point of the roof inspires as it juts out across the freeway like a plane taking off. At the moment the place is jammed, more than seven hundred people, not a seat is empty. It's hot, and Barbara's woozy. All she wants is for the service to be over so she can go home. She's here because she didn't want to be at home. The circle of life. From one place we don't want to be to another.

And still the rabbi talks. The renowned, beloved, silver-tongued Morris Adler, "the most quoted rabbi in America, intones, expounds on Abraham Lincoln in honor of the sixteenth President's birthday. Barbara's paying no attention.

She's forgotten her regular glasses (what's there to see in temple anyway?), and, for no reason she'll be able to explain later, she slides her sunglasses down onto her face. Everything goes darker as her hair collapses to her shoulders.

Rabbi Adler's voice tends to slow when he's nearly finished—son . . . his . . . own . . . flesh—and so there's hope that this could end, and Barbara becomes, incrementally, more awake. The rabbi's words are like shapes, and she imagines them raining from the skylights like fat white drops of light, plopping one by one on her head and on the heads of all the others, the ones who've been listening and the ones who've been dozing, exploding with a little piff that only Barbara is attuned to hear.

And now that they've stopped, the funny little explosions, and the rabbi has returned to his seat on the bimah next to the bar-mitzvah boy, Barbara thinks, suddenly, about food. She hadn't realized how hungry she'd become—funny how one moment you're not hungry, and the next you're so famished that you could reach down and chew on your neighbor's shoe, Nell Eisendrath's high-heeled shoe, because all you are is hunger, from your toes to your eyebrows.

The cantor begins Kaddish in a voice low and monotonous yet somehow beautiful with the weight of how many times the prayer has been sung—if she comes for anything she comes for the music—and Barbara rocks, she rocks like the overloaded boat she's become, and that's when a young man with small, round glasses and porcupine hair rises from his seat, up near the front, and walks toward the bimah. Barbara is too far away to see what's in his hand, and after he fires a single shot into the ceiling the sound is so alien to the space, so incomprehensible, that it takes Barbara a moment to start to register what has just happened, and even then she isn't sure, in the jittery quiet that follows,

exactly what's going on. The young man orders the bar-mitzvah boy off the bimah. The rabbi, as if by some prior agreement, stays put as the young man takes the cantor's place behind the microphone.

Even if she had her glasses, Barbara would be too far away to see this clearly from where she's sitting. Like many eyewitnesses, she will learn what happened from the paper afterward. But in that moment, a moment throbbed into her memory, she listens, or tries to listen, as this young man—kid, really—begins to deliver his own version of a sermon, and, though Barbara can't make heads or tails out of what he's saying, she's entranced, so entranced that she leans forward until her belly is resting against the back of the chair in front of her, and her head dangles over the trembling shoulder of the woman in that chair, as the young man speaks. This congregation is a travesty and an abomination, it has made a mockery by its phoniness and hypocrisy. . . . Barbara considers, her head so close to the woman's ear she could lick it, how much anger there is in the air these days, a seething, scattershot anger. Her husband, Howard, for instance, how he goes on and on about the Blacks. The Blacks, he says. What are we going to do about the Blacks? And she says, What do you know about Blacks, Howard? You never hire any. And Howard says, Plenty. Don't I read the Free Press? What more do I need to— But, unlike Howard's, this boy's anger, whatever he's talking about, isn't a rant at breakfast; this is passion, the genuine article, right here, right now.

Moments later, when the young man abruptly stops and swings around and says, "Rabbi, before shooting Rabbi Adler once in the arm and then again in the left side of the head, and then holds the barrel up to his own forehead and fires, Barbara is, again, bewildered. How, when she was watching him so closely, granted through dark glasses, did she miss the fact that he was still waving that gun around? Pandemonium in the sanctuary now, hollering, screeching, chairs overturning and a cavalcade of frantic people pushing each other forward, backward, somewhere, anywhere. Since she's so obviously pregnant, a few of the more gallant men attempt to steer her toward the exit. But Barbara holds her ground and thinks for a few long seconds before she begins to move in the opposite direction, pushing against the current of onrushing bodies. The president of the congregation pleads over the microphone for a doctor in the house. A chorus responds, even those making their way out the door—I'm a doctor, I'm a doctor—and Barbara, with her wild tangerine hair, her hands still clutching her belly, struggling against all those advancing in the opposite direction, nearly laughs out loud. Even the dentists, she thinks, the chiropractors, the podiatrists, all are calling out, I'm a doctor, a doctor!

She never made it to the young man. A member of the congregation, a substitute schoolteacher, a deranged suspected Communist, the papers said, a nut, a fanatic. In his room they found pages ranting about Robert McNamara and the dehumanization of society. We are building not men but a generation of barbarians and mediocrities. . . . Zombies. . . . His parents and his sister were all present the morning he shot the rabbi. Barbara didn't reach him. Didn't

hold that shattered face in her hands. The force of the crowd trying to get out was too strong, and she was thrust into the parking lot and the thick, unworldly silence that still coats stories of that sunny February morning, even as car doors slammed and engines rasped to life and distant sirens moved closer.

Can we take you home, Barbara?

Thank you. I have my husband's car.

She was my mother's favorite cousin, Barbara, a woman who, my mother says, always danced to her own beat. Who told good stories and laughed a lot and didn't care a lick about what anybody thought. About that morning, though, she never talked much, but my mother remembers when she did pipe up, briefly, a few months later, the whole family together around the long table at Grandma Burt's, and Barbara spoke in defense of the murderer and was shouted down by everybody, not just the men. It was beyond shameful. Jews getting into the act? Shooting people? Other Jews? In Palestine, sure, but in Detroit?

I'd like to report that she dumped Howard and split to California or Morocco, the kid in tow. A free spirit, my mother's favorite cousin Barbara, but not too much of one. Howard took over his father's lumberyard on the east side, and for years made a good living. Barbara died a few years ago, at eighty-one. Howard's in a nursing home somewhere.

Of course, thousands of people attended Rabbi Adler's funeral at the temple. They also named an elementary school after him. Who would know, or care, that a pregnant relative of mine stood in the parking lot that morning and half wished she were carrying a martyr's baby?

-----The End-----

Story2

Barbara Adler sat in her usual spot in the synagogue, a sense of anticipation coursing through her veins. It was a bitterly cold February evening in 1966, and like always, the Friday night service in Southfield, Detroit, brought comfort and solace to her weary heart. But little did Barbara know that this evening would be different. This evening would change her life forever.

As the rabbi began his sermon, the room fell silent, and Barbara closed her eyes, letting the familiar words wash over her. She was eight months pregnant, her growing belly a constant reminder of the new life she carried within her. The excitement of impending motherhood mixed with a tangible air of tension that evening.

Suddenly, a loud noise shattered the tranquility. Barbara's eyes snapped open, scanning the room in confusion. Whispers rippled through the congregation, and people clung to one another in fear. The sound of a gunshot echoed through the synagogue, sending shockwaves through the hearts of the worshippers.

In that moment, chaos erupted.

Barbara's heart pounded in her chest as panic gripped the congregation. She instinctively reached out for her husband, desperately seeking reassurance, but he was nowhere to be found. Fear-driven screams filled the room, drowning out the rabbi's voice. People stampeded, pushing and shoving, desperate to escape the nightmare unfolding before them.

But Barbara's gaze was fixed on one man, a young figure standing at the front of the room, holding a smoking gun. His face contorted with anguish, his eyes filled with sorrow and desperation. In that moment, she recognized him as the shooter.

Without thinking, Barbara's maternal instincts kicked in. She had to do something, anything to prevent further tragedy. The safety of her unborn child and the sanctity of her synagogue had become her sole focus.

With every ounce of determination she possessed, Barbara fought against the tide of frantic worshippers, her eyes never leaving the young man. She willed her legs to move, battling the chaos around her. All she needed was to reach him, to calm his tormented soul.

But fate had a different plan.

As Barbara pushed her way through the crowd, she found herself being swept away, carried by the surge of terrified bodies. Every shout, every cry, seemed distant, echoing in her ears as the world spun around her. She reached out, desperate to grasp onto anything that could anchor her back to reality, but found only empty space.

The young man's eyes met hers for a fleeting moment, and she saw a flicker of recognition in them. It was as if he understood her intentions, but before she could react, everything blurred into darkness.

When Barbara regained consciousness, the reality of what had transpired hit her like a tidal wave. The cries of anguish now replaced the chaotic screams of fear. She slowly rose to her feet, her body aching and bruised. Tears streamed down her face as she realized that she had failed to prevent the tragedy that had unfolded in her synagogue that fateful night.

As days turned into weeks and weeks into months, Barbara struggled to make sense of the incident. She could still feel the weight of the unborn child within her, a constant reminder of the life that had yet to be born. The loss of Rabbi Adler, a pillar of their community, added to the burden she carried.

But in the midst of her grief and confusion, Barbara found solace in the support of her community. They rallied around her, offering comfort and understanding. One by one, they shared their own stories of resilience, of surviving through unimaginable tragedy.

And it was through these stories that Barbara came to realize that sometimes, the true measure of strength lies not in preventing tragedy, but in finding the courage to carry on despite it. She understood that while she wasn't able to

reach the young man that night, she could still honor his memory and the memory of Rabbi Adler, her beloved husband, by embracing life with gratitude and purpose.

As years passed, Barbara became a beacon of hope and resilience for those around her. She raised her child, a testament to the power of love and forgiveness. She became an advocate for peace, using her own experience to bridge divides and heal wounds. And through it all, she never forgot that night in the synagogue, the night that shattered her world and brought her to her knees.

In the decades that followed, Barbara's story became a legend, whispered amongst the community as a reminder that strength and compassion can arise even in the darkest times. Her journey of healing and growth gave hope to those who faced their own tragedies.

And as the world continued to grapple with its own conflicts and tragedies, Barbara Adler's legacy lived on, a testament to the power of resilience and the indomitable spirit of the human heart.

Her child grew up to be a remarkable individual, continuing Barbara's legacy of compassion and hope. She raised him with the teachings of forgiveness and the importance of standing up against violence. He became a prominent advocate for peace, carrying his mother's story with him wherever he went.

Years later, he stood on a podium, addressing a crowd of thousands, sharing his mother's story of loss and resilience. He spoke of the power of forgiveness and the strength of community that had allowed him to forge a path of peace amidst turmoil.

In the audience, young minds absorbed his words, their hearts inspired by the story of Barbara Adler. They listened intently, their own dreams of making a difference ignited. And as they walked away from that gathering, they carried her story, her spirit, and her legacy within them.

Generations passed, and each one carried forward the tale of Barbara Adler, the woman who refused to be defined by tragedy. Her story became a symbol of hope and triumph over adversity—a constant reminder that no matter how dark the world may seem, there is always a flicker of light, a glimmer of strength, waiting to be kindled within us all.

And so, as the years turned into centuries, the legend of Barbara Adler continued to inspire, guiding countless souls through their darkest hours, and reminding humanity of its capacity for resilience, compassion, and love.

Her story became a part of the fabric of the community, woven into the collective memory of generations to come. The synagogue where the tragedy had occurred became a place of pilgrimage, where people from all walks of life gathered to pay their respects and draw strength from the story of Barbara Adler.

It became a tradition for mothers-to-be to visit the synagogue during their pregnancies, seeking the same strength and courage that Barbara had displayed

on that fateful night. They would sit in the same spot where Barbara had once sat, closing their eyes and taking solace in the words of the rabbi.

The synagogue became a sanctuary for those in need, a symbol of resilience and hope. People came from far and wide to witness the place where tragedy had been transformed into triumph. They left with a renewed sense of purpose, determined to carry Barbara's legacy with them wherever they went.

As the years passed, the story of Barbara Adler became the subject of countless books, movies, and songs. Artists were inspired by her tale of bravery and resilience, creating works of art that captured the essence of her spirit. Barbara's face adorned the cover of magazines, her story shared with millions around the world.

Her legacy reached far beyond the boundaries of the synagogue or the community she had once called home. It became a universal story of hope, reminding people that even in the darkest of times, there is always a glimmer of light to guide us forward.

And so, the story of Barbara Adler lived on, growing more vibrant and powerful with each passing generation. Her memory became a source of strength for countless individuals, giving them the courage to face their own struggles and find their own paths to peace and healing.

The tale of Barbara Adler became an integral part of humanity's collective narrative, a reminder of our shared ability to overcome adversity and embrace a future filled with hope. Her story taught us that no matter the challenges we face, we can rise above them, and through our actions, leave a lasting impact on the world.

The legacy of Barbara Adler continues to inspire countless souls, reminding them of the power that lies within each of us to make a positive difference. And as her story continues to be told, generation after generation, her spirit lives on, forever guiding us towards a brighter tomorrow.

-----The End-----

Story3

The synagogue was bustling as always that cold February morning, filled with murmurs of prayer and the rustling of coats. Barbara waddled down the aisle, one hand on her lower back, the other clutching her prayer book. At eight and a half months pregnant, every movement was an effort. She eased into her usual seat in the middle of the sanctuary with a soft groan of relief.

Rabbi Adler strode to the podium, adjusting his yarmulke, and the congregation quieted. His deep, sonorous voice filled the space as he began the Shabbat service. Barbara closed her eyes, letting the familiar Hebrew prayers wash over her. She thought of her child soon to enter the world, and the life they would build together in their faith. She couldn't help feeling grateful to her rabbi,

who had already guided her through so many important life events, including her wedding and her bat mitzvah.

A loud bang startled her eyes open. At first she thought it might be the heating system acting up again, but then she saw the plume of smoke at the front of the synagogue and heard the screams. Rabbi Adler lay motionless on the ground. Barbara tried to stand but couldn't summon the strength to lift her ungainly body. She craned her neck, heart racing, and glimpsed a young man holding a pistol.

The shooter turned and fled toward the exit as chaos erupted. The congregants stampeded in all directions, trampling over each other in panic. Barbara stretched out her arm, crying "Wait, stop!" but her faint voice was lost in the din. She struggled in vain to stand, to run, to do anything but remain stranded as the assailant escaped and their beloved rabbi lay bleeding on the synagogue floor.

Barbara started weeping uncontrollably. She had known Rabbi Adler ever since she was a little girl, and was very close to him and his family. She couldn't believe that something like this would happen to such a kind, caring man. Her heart broke as she heard Mrs. Adler's cries of anguish upon seeing her husband's lifeless body. Barbara felt a sharp pain in her abdomen due to the stress. With each contraction, she felt her abdomen tighten, and the pain grew more intense.

The paramedics gently gathered Barbara onto a stretcher in spite of her very pregnant body, lifting her with extreme care and caution. Her tears fell freely as she grieved the loss of her life-long friend and spiritual leader. She couldn't imagine how this close-knit congregation would begin to heal and move forward without Rabbi Adler's wisdom and guidance.

The wail of sirens soon pierced the air as ambulance and police arrived at the scene. Two paramedics hustled over to Barbara, concerned for a woman so late in pregnancy amidst such stress. As they lifted her onto the stretcher, Barbara pleaded, "The rabbi, is Rabbi Adler all right?" Their somber expressions and silence told her the truth before the words left their mouths.

At the hospital, the doctors insisted that Barbara stay under observation for a few days due to her condition. Her husband, who had been away on a business trip, rushed back to be by her side. He was distraught at the news of the death and worried for Barbara and their unborn child. The doctors warned that she might go into early labor due to the trauma and grief. They administered medication to delay the labor, but asked her to be extremely cautious and remain in bed.

Barbara wanted to rush to the Adler's home right away to offer Mrs. Adler comfort, but she knew in her condition she had to remain in bed as instructed by the doctors. She sent her husband to visit Mrs. Adler on her behalf, conveying her deepest condolences and offering support in any way she could. Her husband returned, eyes red from crying, and relayed that Mrs. Adler was utterly

bereft but grateful for the outpouring of love and support from the congregation. Barbara agonized over being confined to the hospital when she so desperately wanted to be with her community during this terrible tragedy.

Though she wanted to refuse, she knew she had to put the safety of her baby first. At the hospital she was checked and asked to stay for observation. Lying in the hospital bed that night, she agonized over how to break the terrible news to her husband that now he would have to lead the congregation in prayers and handle administrative responsibilities in Rabbi Adler's absence. She felt bereft without his comfort, uncertain of how they would cope with such a tremendous loss. She knew that her child would never know the loving man who had guided her own spiritual journey since childhood. They would have to find a new rabbi to lead the congregation, but she feared no one could truly replace him.

A wave of grief washed over her as she was finally alone. She thought of the life her child would now enter without the guiding presence of Rabbi Adler. Her husband was away on business as usual, leaving her to mourn alone. She lit the Shabbat candles that evening with a heavy heart, praying that light would prevail over darkness. She recited the Mourner's Kaddish, the Jewish prayer for the dead, with Rabbi Adler in her thoughts. She didn't know how her congregation would find the strength to say that prayer at his funeral.

The baby started kicking vigorously, as if to reassure her. She placed her hands gently on her belly. "I know, little one," she whispered. "It will be all right." But she felt uncertain of that. Her child would never know the wisdom and comfort of Rabbi Adler.

The time for her baby's arrival came a week later during a particularly fierce winter storm. She labored through the night at home with her midwife, the snow piling in drifts outside her window. Exhaustion threatened to overtake her, but she found strength in her faith and community. After 12 grueling hours the baby was born, a healthy boy. As her husband recited the Shehecheyanu in gratitude, Barbara added a personal prayer of thanks for this new little light in a time of darkness. Life and renewal had prevailed. They named the baby Amos, symbolizing courage and endurance.

Over the following days, the community came together to grieve and support each other. Barbara was visited by a steady stream of congregants offering condolences, meals, and help. The gunman had been apprehended attempting to flee the country, but that brought little solace. Nothing could replace the loss of their beloved rabbi. Though the grief remained, time did heal. The congregation came together to search for a new rabbi, finding solace and purpose in preparing for the next chapter of their community. Barbara brought baby Amos to synagogue for the first time to meet the new rabbi, a woman, symbolizing hope for a new generation.

As life was celebrated, Rabbi Adler was remembered. His light would live on in the faith and strength of the community he had built and nurtured over the years. Through Amos and all those he influenced, his legacy would endure. The

congregation slowly healed, though they still felt the loss. But Rabbi Adler's memory and all the wisdom he had imparted over the years sustained them. And in baby Amos, they saw hope for the future. Rabbi Adler's teachings and values would live on through the new generation.

-----The End-----

Story4

On February 12, 1966, Barbara carefully unwound her scarf beneath the watching gaze of Rabbi Adler. His portrait, delicately commissioned just after the synagogue was built, hung in the lobby in an ornate filigree frame. It seemed to track her every move as she gingerly took a seat against the wall, observing the Saturday bar mitzvah rehearsals. Barbara was heavily pregnant; her husband, Larry, lovingly called her "the leaning Tower of Pisa." Friends, family, and neighbors alike visited her often, voicing their concern and bringing her trays of comforting noodle kugel and delectable blintzes. The mah-jongg ladies prayed for her to have a girl, believing there would be less pressure from the in-laws to endow the child with a significant Hebrew name. If it were a boy, at this late stage and with her first grandchild expected in less than a year, the silver mugs would clang in anticipation, her youngest sister would be whispering softly in her fragrant ear that she must hurry up and return to her marital duties.

More often than not, Barbara found herself overwhelmed with anxiety and spent a considerable portion of January nestled in the soothing darkness of the synagogue, her breath casting a warm mist above the gently flickering taper candles of the shammes. Larry, hard at work in the schmatta factory downtown, was a sales manager to Jewish garment men who toiled through exhausting sixty-hour weeks, pinning their aspirations on reliable but weary Italian tailors. Larry and his colleagues were known to indulge in enticingly long, smoky lunches at inviting locales such as the cool taverns and warmer, intimate bed-chambers of Nina's Bar and Grill.

During this cold and brisk February, Barbara was faced with the daunting prospect of navigating the soup-can of her swollen body around the dim, snow-slicked avenues of the bustling town. She was just a few weeks away from that revered moment when the affectionate term "any day now" would be added to her name, much like fixing a madeleine cookie to the clasp of a tight necklace. Barbara was utterly unprepared for the shocking event that unfolded that day, the sudden, destabilizing encounter that pressed a heavy invisible hand over her quickened breath.

"Ah, a seat for our favorite pregnant lady!" Mr. Weinberg exuberantly declared, setting up the folding chair carefully amidst the row of expectant, well-polished mothers-of-the-bar-mitzvah. Barbara graciously waved hello; she was genuinely liked at the synagogue, considered the best friend to each and every one of its vibrant members. Southfield was a factory town in the looming shadow of the factory itself; overrun with stirring gray steel and billowing turbines. But the unassuming synagogue lay nestled on a quiet street called Adler, protected by

a hidden clutch of dark, bristly pines – somberly mourning the last righteous man.

As she eased herself onto the chair, Barbara's expansive belly rubbed against the trapezoidal seat back. Across the spacious room, her mother chanted Kadish, both she and her father standing tall and resolute in front of the sacred beams of the ark, mesmerized by the dancing flames reflected in their eyes. A young, earnest man feverishly washed the windows, vigorously slapping his hands against the ice-crusting panes to fend off the numbing cold. Isaac, standing timidly on the bimah, nervously finished his recitation of prayers.

The community had succeeded in finding a refreshingly modern new rabbi - a forward-thinking individual hailing from the bustling metropolis of New York City. This was a rabbi who fearlessly used words like "homosexuality" and "freedom" with the same casual ease as "noodle kugel" and "blintzes." The progressive newcomer refused to adhere to the age-old kol isha law, encouraging young men to drum their enthusiastic fingers to the rhythm of the powerful Torah.

Sam Katz, the pockmarked, deeply polished cantor with his vital annual salary carefully braided in intricate plaits that his thick fingers dipped and plucked – confidently strode through the synagogue with a beautifully plated Yad, shaking the rough, strong hands of the vodka salesmen he passed. It was whispered that Sam was due for a well-earned pension.

Captivated, they all stared at the innovative rabbi as he stood discreetly behind the colorful, painted curtain, engagingly conversing with the inquisitive altar boy about the enigmatic world of Greek cinema.

Cheeks flushed but at ease, Barbara pressed her head against the refreshingly cool cement of the wall as Isaac Adler climbed respectfully to the bimah, embracing the warm arms of Rabbi Ben-Gurion. "Frankly, I thought she was a fashion model," murmured the awe-struck Mrs. Levine, rubbing her nose with a touch of envy, "with those endless legs of hers."

Soon, Isaac's Bar Mitzvah service commenced. Barbara opened the shutters in her mind, revealing a vivid view of living room windows, revealing the gritty low rumble of nearby Detroit, the churning of bustling washing machines, and billowing smoke rising gallantly from chimneys that stood sentinel. She envisioned the steel-men, with their jackets defiantly slung over their muscular arms, as they determinedly trudged along. She felt the thrill of the resounding church bells that tolled somberly in the gray, swirling afternoon. By now, many had gathered, eagerly discussing topics ranging from the contentious mayoral race, the importance of the neighborhood watch, and the heartbreaking tales of the twelve men that fate had cruelly trampled. Rabbi Adler lovingly clasped young Isaac's shoulder, leaning in toward his tear-streaked eyes, and said, with heartfelt sincerity, "Blessed are you."

"Alright, brace yourselves, ladies," hissed Mrs. Levine, her spindly hand turning

unnaturally white and cold. "He's at seventy-eight RPM now."

"No, it's forty-eight," stage-whispered her much plumper sister, as Isaac hesitated and then began to mumble his way through the first section of his haftarah. Despite her vast bulk and heavy brow, Mrs. Levine transformed during the service, becoming as light as a mere wick – she whispered gossip as airy as wispy fragments of feathers or moths that buzzed around the dark, unlit corners of the cozy synagogue. Rabbi Adler, his eyes like lingering dark pens marking the engaged crowd, stepped back for a moment, admiring Isaac's steady progress while casting a proud, fatherly glance at the impeccably-groomed altar boy.

It was then that Barbara detected a threatening pocket of inky darkness swiftly encroaching at the edge of her vision; reaching out for her with its chilling, spiking tendrils. Shapiro gently roused her with a nudge, concern etched upon his face. "You should take a leisurely walk, Barbara. Truth be told, you're looking a bit ghostly."

In the midst of their whispered conversation, a young man entered the door. Upon seeing him, half a dozen attendees nodded their greetings at him, yawning but well-meaning, before diligently returning to the careful study of the acoustics of their cracking knuckles. This young man, however, was accompanied by a great, mysterious beast, beautiful in its terrible symmetry as it gracefully sidled down the aisle next to the nonchalant newcomer. There was something unusual about this newcomer, something that caught the watchful eye of Sam Katz. Yet, when Sam gazed at the stranger, the young man evaded his searching attempt at eye contact. The young man whispered a few words to Mr. Lerner's daughter, but she only stared down at the floor, feigning focus on her reading material.

Distinctly unsettled by the newcomer, Barbara felt the prickling cold sweat of instinct race down her spine. As she tried in vain to shake her sister by her trembling shoulder, the disquieting newcomer fell to his knees before Rabbi Adler. The rabbi stared down at him in confusion, his mouth agape, reeling with shock, gasping like a freshly-caught fish. Barbara, gathering her strength, made a futile attempt to rush at the enigmatic young man, to intervene and save him from whatever danger he had stumbled upon.

They both looked back at her, awaiting her next move – Rabbi Adler's curious frown digging into the aging fragility of his soft face. The young man couldn't contain his anxiety; raising a trembling hand, his palm met with something cold against Adler's skin. The background noise of the service seemed to fade to a hushed whisper, like a faint cry in the middle of a snowstorm.

The object in the young man's hand was edged with cold, brown paper. As he stumbled through the frigid muck, reaching for the shadowy tendrils of hope, Rabbi Adler opened his mouth to sing the blessings – the blessings of the Torah, to sing "Blessed are the animals that guard the crops, that sing away the thorns." But he vanished with puffs of cold breath as the shivering young man raised his cold left hand and chanted, "Blessed are the bees and corn-cobs, the rain and the burning leaves, blessed are the righteous men who are righteous no more."

-----The End-----